

Leading light: Ritu Phogat is among the most accomplished Indian wrestlers to transition into MMA.

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promotions where your opponents are of a really high standard, possibly even former UFC-level fighters. That doesn't exist in India. Our biggest promotion is Matrix Fight Night. But even they only conduct maybe three or four events each year. And not every fighter will get the chance to compete in every event. That means our best talent doesn't get to compete as often as they should," he explains.

Moreover, with many of the best Indian fighters locked into long contracts with MFN, there remains the possibility — as happened with Chungreng — that they might be unable to compete at the right time.

Financial struggles

For any fighter looking to improve, the lack of quality sparring and competition means

they often have no choice but to go overseas for better training. However, this comes with its own set of complications. Training abroad costs money, and at all levels of the sport, that's in short supply.

"Even right now, it is a struggle to get the kind of support we need," admits coach Siddharth. "I remember there was a press conference before her last fight where Puja actually said she was broke and looking for sponsors. I think there's a distinction between what's popular and what's acceptable right now. MMA is popular in the sense that when there are fights coming up, Anshul is the hottest thing on the internet, and everyone wants to talk about it. But when it comes to sponsoring Anshul or Puja, sponsors will say it's a blood sport,"

he adds.

Despite Anshul's large celebrity following on Instagram, it is understood that, despite reaching out to them for help connecting with sponsors, he has received no response.

For India's top fighters, this means that training isn't just about getting better — it's also about carefully managing limited finances. "The fact of the matter is that most Indian fighters train in Indonesia because it's relatively affordable compared to training anywhere else," says Siddharth. But even 'relatively' doesn't make it easy. "Training in Indonesia costs about Rs 2 lakhs a month, and that's not even including flights. If you train there for 10 months a year, that works out to around Rs 20 lakhs. And as a fighter, you get about \$20,000 per fight. So even if you fight just once, you're actually losing around Rs 4 lakhs. We try to manage as best we can. We compromise on flights, accommodation, and even coffee sometimes just to have enough to train. Anshul got \$50,000 as prize money when he won Road to UFC, but after that, things have been really hard," he says.

Despite the challenges, most observers of MMA in India remain optimistic about the future. According to Forrest Griffin (**facing page**), former UFC champion and current vice president of the UFC Performance Institute, success is a self-fulfilling cycle. He isn't too concerned about the immediate lack of success of Indian fighters as long

A photograph of Ritu Phogat, an Indian MMA fighter, in a black ONE Championship singlet and gloves, smiling in the ring. A large yellow text box is overlaid on the bottom right of the image.

"WHAT IS HOLDING US BACK IS THE LACK OF A BIG AND SOLID ECOSYSTEM WHERE OUR HOMEGROWN ATHLETES HAVE ACCESS TO THE RIGHT PLATFORMS, THE RIGHT PLACES TO TRAIN..." — SIDDHARTH SINGH, ANSHUL JUBLI'S COACH